owed his allegiance first to the local chieftain who raised and paid him, not to the Durrani shahs in faraway Kabul or Peshawar.

Yet even the tribal leaders had frequently been unable to guarantee obedience, for tribal authority was itself so elusive and diffuse. As the saying went: Behind every hillock there sits an emperor – *pusht-e har teppe, yek padishah neshast* (or alternatively: Every man is a khan – *har saray khan deh*).[48] In such a world, the state never had a monopoly on power, but was just one among a number of competing claimants on allegiance. 'An Afghan Amir sleeps upon an ant heap,' went the proverb.[49] Elphinstone grasped this as he watched Shah Shuja's rule disintegrate around him. 'The internal government of the tribes answers its ends so well', he wrote, 'that the utmost disorders of the royal government never derange its operations, nor disturb the lives of its people.'[50] No wonder that Afghans proudly thought of their mountains as Yaghistan – the Land of Rebellion.[51]

Many of the tribes had lived for centuries by offering neighbouring empires their services in return for the political equivalent of protection money: even at the height of the Mughal Empire, for example, the emperors far away in Delhi and Agra had realised that it was hopeless even to think of attempting to tax the Afghan tribes. Instead the only way to keep open communication with the Mughals' Central Asian homelands was for them to pay the tribes massive annual subsidies: during Aurangzeb's rule 600,000 rupees a year was paid by the Mughal exchequer to Afghan tribal leaders to secure their loyalty, Rs 125,000 going to the Afridi tribe alone. Yet, even so, Mughal control of Afghanistan was intermittent at best, and even the victorious Nadir Shah, fresh from looting Delhi in 1739, paid the chiefs huge sums for providing him with safe passage through the Khyber, in both directions.[52d] There were other options: the Afghans could be lured into accepting the authority of a leader if he tempted them with a four-fifths share of the plunder and spoils of conquest, as Ahmad Shah Abdali and Timur Shah had both done.[53] But without a ruler with a full treasure chest, or the lure of plunder to cement the country's different interest groups, Afghanistan almost always tended to fragment: its few moments of coherence were built on the successes of its armies, never of its administration.

This was certainly how it was beginning to look for Shah Shuja and what was left of his grandfather's empire. By May 1809, two months after the arrival of Elphinstone's Embassy, the full scale of the disaster facing him